A Statue of Simon Bolivar

By Eric Lane

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *When your parents split up it's hard. Especially when your Dad starts dating other women. It's hard to get past the "ick" factor.*

ACTRESS 2: *There's no other way to say it: Dating sucks when you're in your 40s.*

ACTRESS 1: *In this selection, Elizabeth, is trying a bit too hard to find that elusive first date and to remain hopeful in the process (Actress playing Elizabeth begins to examine herself in a pocket mirror, smoothing eyebrows, pinching her cheeks and making "eyes" at herself -- Actress playing Jemma rolls her eyes, puts in her headphone and starts rocking out to some music)*

ACTRESS 2: *And Jemma is dealing with her father, who obviously is not wading into the dating world very well*

ACTRESS 1: *The two meet in New York City's Central Park on a bench near*

TOGETHER: *A Statue of Simon Bolivar by Eric Lane*

New York City. The statue of Bolivar, South entrance of Central Park at Sixth Ave. JEMMA, a fourteen-year-old, is seated on a bench. ELIZABETH stands. She looks off for her date, who is late. She fixes her lipstick.

JEMMA: That shit'll kill ya.

ELIZABETH: Excuse me?

JEMMA: Lipstick. There are studies. Lab rats. The shit they developed, you don't wanna know.

ELIZABETH: You're right. I don't.

JEMMA: Government studies. Big bucks for putting Revlon on rat lips. Some world, huh?

ELIZABETH: I suppose. Look, do you know what time it is? *(JEMMA extends her arm, showing her watch.)* Thank you.

JEMMA: You like Bolivar?

ELIZABETH: *(Re watch.)* Yes, it's lovely.

JEMMA: Not the watch. The general. Simon Bolivar. *(Indicates statue.)* Big-ass statue

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and nobody even bothers. El Liberador. The George Washington of South America. Won independence for Bolivia, Panama, Columbia, Ecuador, Venezuela, and Peru. You want a Tic-Tac?

ELIZABETH: No thank you. If you don't mind ...

JEMMA: I don't mind. What else I got to do?

ELIZABETH: I meant I'm waiting for someone.

JEMMA: He ain't showing.

ELIZABETH: That's a terrible thing to say.

JEMMA: True.

ELIZABETH: You don't know that.

JEMMA: I know.

ELIZABETH: You don't know that.

JEMMA: I know.

ELIZABETH: You *don't* know that! *(A beat.)*

JEMMA: I know.

ELIZABETH: Why don't you go away?

JEMMA: Can't.

ELIZABETH: I'm sure there's another plaque somewhere in the park you can memorize. Bethesda Fountain or Cleopatra's Needle. A wealth of information for a young girl of your perspicacity.

JEMMA: Nah, I'm meeting somebody.

ELIZABETH: He won't show.

JEMMA: He's a she.

ELIZABETH: Either way. She's not coming.

JEMMA: You don't know that.

ELIZABETH: I know.

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JEMMA: You don't know that.

ELIZABETH: I know;

JEMMA: You don't know that 'cause she's here.

ELIZABETH: Excuse me. Unless you're meeting some imaginary friend-

JEMMA: I'm Jem.

ELIZABETH: And ... ?

JEMMA: *(Extends hand.)* Nice to meet you, Elizabeth.

ELIZABETH: Excuse me? How do you know my name?

JEMMA: Elizabeth M. Cunningham; The M's for Marie.

ELIZABETH: How do you ... Who are you?

JEMMA: Jem.

ELIZABETH: Jem who?

JEMMA: Jem Hollingshead. Ring a bell?

ELIZABETH: Look, I don't know what you think you're --

JEMMA: My dad's your date. At least he was supposed to be. Nicholas I. Hollingshead. I for Ivan. Can you believe naming your kid Ivan? I don't have any kids. I'm not gonna. Fish is okay, but kids suck. I hate kids. I hate cheese. I hate jelly. And I really hate it when my food touches.

ELIZABETH: So where's your father?

JEMMA: Where's he always? Work. Too busy. Story of my life. Something came up, so guess who gets to go in his place. I mean, if you're gonna go to a benefit and buy all the raffle tickets, at least go out on the date when you win it. Instead of sending me.

ELIZABETH: Why would he buy all the raffle tickets and then send you?

JEMMA: He'd send me to take a crap for him if he could figure out how.

ELIZABETH: Well, thanks for the information and the apology.

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JEMMA: You're better off. He's an asshole.

ELIZABETH: He's still your father ...

JEMMA: He's still an asshole.

ELIZABETH: I tend to agree.

JEMMA: Like, if you're gonna bid on a date for some lame-ass charity, at least pick one with a decent T-shirt.

ELIZABETH: It's not lame-ass. It's a very worthy cause.

JEMMA: *(Rolls her eyes.)* Kidneys for Kids. Try wearing *that* to gym class. You don't look so good, you wanna sit down?

ELIZABETH: No, I'm fine.

JEMMA: You don't look fine. You look like somebody just gave you a big-ass wedgie and you're hoping nobody noticed.

ELIZABETH: I said I'm fine. Thank you.

JEMMA: So where are we going?

ELIZABETH: I don't know where *you're* going, but I'm heading home.

JEMMA: He'll cancel the check. If you don't take me.

ELIZABETH: He wouldn't dare.

JEMMA: You don't know him. Growing up with the middle name Ivan. That shit's deadly. He's probable to do anything. Trust me.

ELIZABETH: The date's off.

JEMMA: I'll tell.

ELIZABETH: Go ahead.

JEMMA: And some baby needing a new kidney instead's gonna wind up with monkey glands. What kinda shit is that to live with?

ELIZABETH: I'm sure they'll work it out.

JEMMA: I mean ***you***. Knowing you coulda helped but turned your back at the exact moment of need. That's a heavy burden to bear.

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ELIZABETH: I've borne worse.

JEMMA: Tell me about it. And cheese. Did I mention that? I hate cheese.

ELIZABETH: I hate your dad.

JEMMA: Welcome to my life. We could kill him.

ELIZABETH: Right.

JEMMA: Serious. I could. I'm still a juvenile. You could watch. There's no way you could've stopped me. You tried, but I was out of my mind. Years of neglect culminating in one final swipe of the ax. *(She demonstrates giving him a whack with the ax.)*

ELIZABETH: You'd go to jail.

JEMMA: Good behavior, I'm outta there in no time. TV deal covers the legal fees. A TV movie. Drew Barrymore plays me.

ELIZABETH: Who plays me?

JEMMA: Susan Lucci. *(ELIZABETH just looks at her.)* Okay, Betty White. I don't know. Somebody. Who do you want?

ELIZABETH: I have no idea.

JEMMA: C'mon, you must've thought about it.

ELIZABETH: Never.

JEMMA: Some night when you're lying in bed with your cat and you can't fall asleep 'cause you keep thinking about that asshole who stood you up -- even though you told yourself not to believe. Even though you knew it wouldn't work, some part of you still hoping, believing that maybe --

ELIZABETH: I don't have a cat.

JEMMA: No?

ELIZABETH: No. *(A beat.)* I have· two cats.

JEMMA: Two cats and you never thought about who'd play you in the TV movie? I find that hard to believe. *(ELIZABETH just looks at her.)* What.

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ELIZABETH: Susan Sarandon.

JEMMA: *(Not quite buying it. Over-articulates each letter.)* O-K.

ELIZABETH: What?

JEMMA: Nothing.

ELIZABETH: Not nothing. I detect a certain air of sarcasm in your voice.

JEMMA: That's not sarcasm. That's life. So where we going?

ELIZABETH: How old are you?

JEMMA: Fourteen, but that's not my fault.

ELIZABETH: Fourteen. Jeez.

JEMMA: I won't ask how old you are.

ELIZABETH: No?

JEMMA: You'd probably make me guess, then get all offended and shit. No thank you.

ELIZABETH: That's what? Seventh grade.

JEMMA: *(Incredulous, corrects her.)* Eighth.

ELIZABETH: Eighth grade.

JEMMA: You like to row? *(ELIZABETH just looks at her.)* What? That's good exercise for you.

ELIZABETH: I'm not rowing.

JEMMA: Bicycle? We can rent them. Rollerblades? Merry-goround? *(No response.)* That's okay. We can just sit here.

ELIZABETH: I'll give you ten minutes.

JEMMA: Two hours.

ELIZABETH: Ten-

JEMMA: You'd spend at least that with my dad, and he's a dick. *(A beat.)*

ELIZABETH: One hour.

JEMMA: One hour. Okay.

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ELIZABETH: *(Looks at Jemma's watch.)* Starting now. *(A pause. Neither speaks. After a moment)* How'd he do that? Bolivar. Win their freedom. *(Jemma shrugs.)* Wouldn't that be something?

JEMMA: What?

ELIZABETH: To do something so extraordinary that people build a statue.

JEMMA: Yeah, and pigeons shit all over it. *(Elizabeth looks at her, then laughs.)* What?

ELIZABETH: I think you're missing the point.

JEMMA: Which is ...

ELIZABETH: Nothing.

JEMMA: Yeah. Nothing. *(They sit together and look out, Lights fade.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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